

Upholding the Social Contract: Teaching the “Why” of Professionalism, Not Just the “What”

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Disclosure Statement

Nothing to Disclose.

Learning Objectives

What you will take away from this session

1

Foundations

Describe how the social contract, fiduciary duties, and the primacy of patient interests underpin professionalism.

2

Two Concepts

Differentiate between deficit- and strength-focused concepts of professionalism.

3

Regulation in Practice

Explain how regulatory expectations are aligned with day-to-day professional behaviors.

Professionalism Through a Regulatory Lens

Three ideas that sit beneath every regulatory expectation

Professionalism

In the Medical field, professionalism means being altruistic — prioritizing the patient's welfare above personal, financial, or institutional interests.

Fiduciary Duties

The ethical and sometimes legal obligations physicians must fulfill to promote patients' best interests, placing these interests above their own.

The Social Contract

An implicit agreement whereby society grants medicine trust and autonomy in return for competence, accountability, and ethical conduct. Professionalism is how that trust is sustained, not an optional extra.

The Social Contract

A two-way exchange of expectations between society and the profession

Society Expectations of Health Professionals	Health Professionals' Expectation of Society
• Skilled, effective, and competent care	• Professional autonomy
• Ethical, honest, and trustworthy conduct	• Well-regulated and resourced healthcare system
• Commitment to serving patients	• Trust, respect, and fair compensation
• Objective, evidence informed care	• Input into public policy
• Accountability	• The ability to self-regulate

Deficit- vs. Strength-Focused Concepts

Two ways of framing professionalism — and what each one teaches

DEFICIT-FOCUSED

Concepts of professionalism that identify a lack of professionalism, professional misconduct, or negligence.

STRENGTH-FOCUSED

Concepts of professionalism that highlight specific, observable actions strengthening trust, safety, learning, and teamwork.

DIVISION OF CONSUMER AFFAIRS
STATE BOARD OF MEDICAL EXAMINERS

IN THE MATTER OF THE :
SUSPENSION OR REVOCATION :
OF THE LICENSE OF :
[REDACTED] :
[REDACTED] :
[REDACTED] :
[REDACTED] :
[REDACTED] :
[REDACTED] :
[REDACTED] :
[REDACTED] :
[REDACTED] :
[REDACTED] :

ADMINISTRATIVE ACTION
INTERIM CONSENT ORDER

TO PRACTICE MEDICINE AND :
SURGERY IN THE STATE OF :
NEW JERSEY :

This matter was opened to the State Board of Medical
Examiners ("Board") upon the receipt of information alleging
that [REDACTED] M.D. committed professional misconduct and
that the Board

What Positive Professionalism Looks Like

Each value translated into a behavioral standard, not a broad label

Respect

“Pause before entering, introduce everyone in the room, and ask the patient how they want to be addressed.”

Accountability

“Before leaving, identify the owner and deadline for every outstanding item.”

Humility

“When unsure, state the uncertainty, consult the right person, and report back.”

Integrity

“Correct a misleading statement or documentation error promptly, even when no one else has noticed.”

Civility Under Pressure

“Name the concern, state the facts, and propose the next safe step without personal attack.”

Feedback Receptivity

“Thank the person, clarify what they observed, identify one change, and revisit progress.”

The Keys to Public Trust

The rationale for medical self-regulation rests on public trust. While state medical boards support this rationale, it is the physician's daily actions that earn and uphold this public trust.

Select **each** flip card to learn more.



Upholding Public Trust

State medical boards and physicians are integral components of the medical profession. They share a mutual goal: protecting patients and advancing quality care.



BOARDS:

Ensure competence, ethics, and public accountability.



PHYSICIANS:

Model professional integrity and take action when professional standards are at risk, which includes fulfilling fiduciary duties and adhering to professional ethical codes.

Select **NEXT** to continue.



TOGETHER:

Demonstrate that medicine can govern itself responsibly.



Select **NEXT** to continue.

Sustaining Trust Through Action

Trust is sustained through action, achieved primarily through self-regulation and individual effort to maintain professional standards.

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PROFESSIONALISM

The Physician's Role in Public Trust

Select **START COURSE** to begin.

START COURSE



Call to Action

Next steps for FSMB and certification organizations

Working together with certification organizations to advance professionalism in medicine.

Collaborate

Establish ongoing collaboration with certification organizations, such as ABMS, to recognize and reinforce the essential role of professionalism in medicine.

Share

Share insights, resources, and lessons learned to strengthen approaches to promoting and assessing professionalism across the continuum of medicine.

Advance

Work together to advance and promote professionalism across medical education, certification programs, and the broader healthcare community.

THANK YOU